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Expert-Approved Ways to Fix a Problem



1 Step back and take stock.

How important and/or urgent are your problems? Do they really need to be solved by you? Craig Sawchuk, PhD, professor of psychology and chair of the Division of Integrated Behavioral Health at the Mayo Clinic in Rochester, MN, suggests writing this step out to help slow down your emotions, and to improve the flexibility of your thinking. This in turn can help with your problem-solving abilities.



2 Remind yourself of typical outcomes.

Most problems aren't new. You've either dealt with them before — at least in some familiar way — or someone else around you has as you watched. If you've dealt with a problem like your current one before, how did it turn out? Did you handle it better than what you originally thought? Was it actually the end of the world?

(The answer to that is no, it was not.)



3 Brainstorm new potential solutions.

Generating potential ideas again helps with flexibility in thinking, particularly if any factors have changed since the last time you dealt with a similar problem (ie. you're at a new job with a new boss, but the issue is the same, or you've instituted specific boundaries with your family since the last time this issue popped up). By doing this step, you'll hopefully avoid spending too much time on solutions you've tried in the past that may have sapped your energy and brainpower. At the very least, it will give you a method to move forward and resolve those issues when they do arise.



4 Pick a solution and identify steps to address them.

Sometimes the problem isn't making the best or right decision, it's actually making a decision and going forward. In other words, it's often more about avoiding our tendencies towards indecisiveness than anything else.



5 Evaluate the outcomes.

Evaluating the outcomes includes rechecking on Step No. 2. If you did something different this time and it worked out better than it did before, what changed? (ie. Maybe the last time your mom guilted you into flying home for Easter you caved. This time, maybe you instituted some boundaries.)

If you didn't get the outcome you were hoping for, how might what you did today combined with elements from what you did last time work together in case the issue comes up in the future?

Dr. Sawchuck also said that it's important to remember that:

1. We cannot control everything, and
2. At what point are we banging our head against a brick wall?

"This is why evaluating our progress and outcomes is important," he added. "Sometimes, expending too much effort and energy into a problem can become a stressor in and of itself, especially if problem-solving has been ineffective."



If that's the case, then taking some time to focus on building up buffers and/or our resiliency can help us deal with the erosion of stressors over time. Building resilience can also lower emotions and improve flexibility of thinking.

Typical restorative things, says Dr. Sawchuck, might include:

- 1 Focusing on the basics of wellness, like getting enough sleep, eating well, and regular exercise.
- 2 Finding ways to relax throughout the day, or at least week.
- 3 Engaging in personally meaningful, value-driven activities.
- 4 Surrounding yourself with healthy social supports. Do the people you hang with reliably bring you up or down?

Keep in mind that bouncing problems off of others can be helpful, but it depends on who you're bouncing things off of. They can either escalate the situation, or help make it more manageable. "Also be aware of what is on your plate, and do you have the capacity to deal with certain problems at any given moment in time," Dr. Sawchuck added. "Sometimes we end up taking on too many responsibilities, almost with an inflated sense of responsibility for being the one who needs to solve the problem. Delegation can be helpful, and sometimes challenging beliefs about excessive responsibilities may need to be addressed."



You've got this